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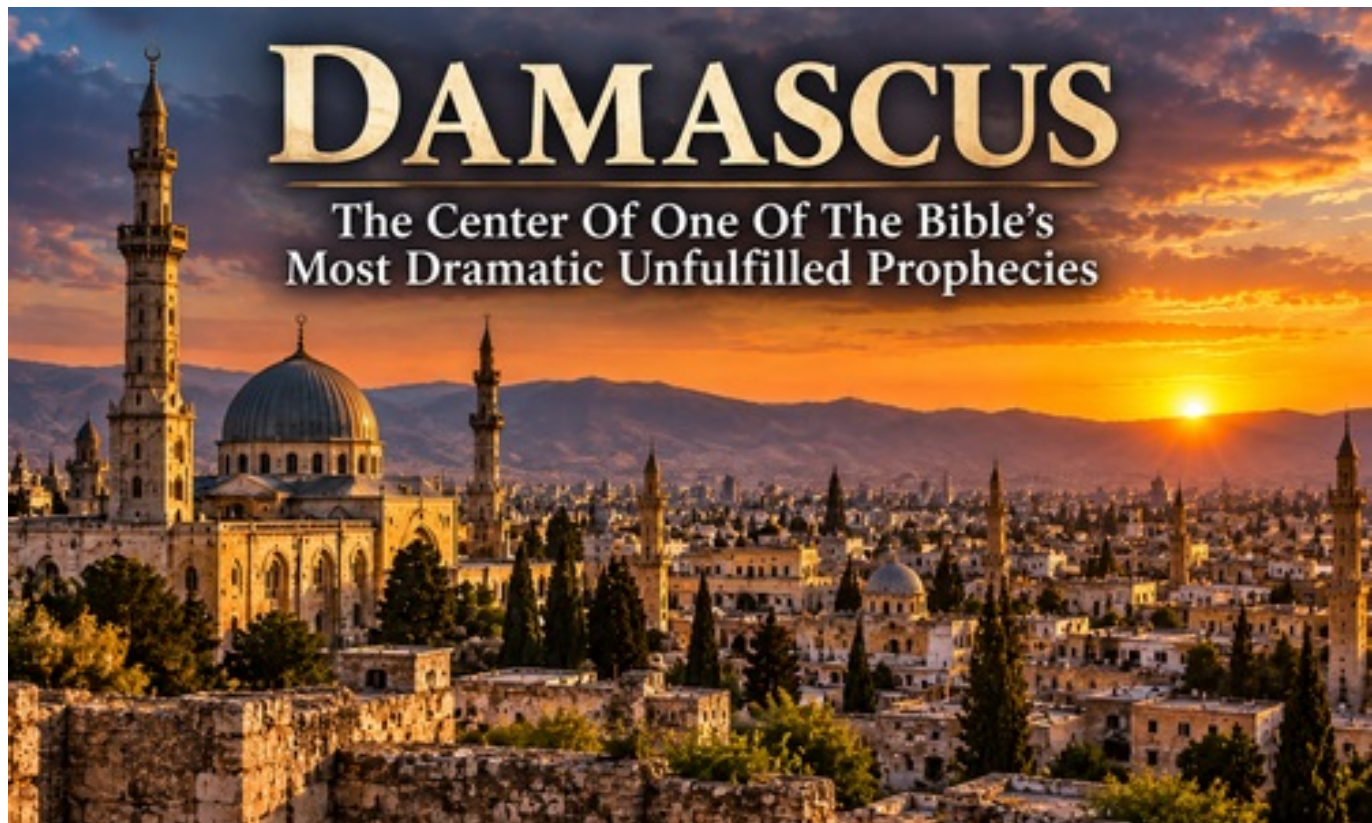
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ARTICLE

Damascus: The Center Of One Of The Bible's Most Dramatic Unfulfilled Prophecies



BY DAVID BOWEN/HARBING'S DAILY SEPTEMBER 08, 2026

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There are moments when a headline deserves more than a passing glance.

There are moments when the words being spoken in the Middle East should cause students of Bible prophecy to stop, listen, and open their Bibles. One of those moments is presently unfolding in Syria.

Reports and photos have recently emerged of the Syrian Arab Army soldiers standing in formation outside the historic Damascus Citadel and chanting violent threats directed toward Jews. According to published the soldiers declared that they were coming for the Jew and spoke of making Jewish blood flow like rivers.

These were not simply civilians arguing on social media. They were members of Syria's military. Standing in Damascus. For students of Bible prophecy, these details are hard to ignore.

Damascus is not merely another Middle Eastern capital. It is a city whose name appears in one of the Bible's most dramatic unfulfilled prophecies.

A New Syria, but an Old Hatred?

When Bashar al-Assad's government collapsed in December 2024, the world began asking what kind of Syria would emerge from the ruins. Would Syria eventually become more moderate? Would a new government seek peaceful relations with Israel? Could Damascus move away from the Iranian axis that had dominated Syrian affairs? Or would one hostile regime simply be replaced by another?

Those questions have been answered by the military chants and should not be dismissed merely as rhetoric. In December 2025, Syrian soldiers participating in a military parade in Damascus were already recorded chanting their support for Gaza. Arabic reporting documented chants expressing solidarity with Gaza during events marking the anniversary of Assad's fall.

By May 2026, an official Syrian army video anthem was attracting attention for imagery carrying unmistakable messages toward Israel. The production reportedly showed the Golan Heights and Mount Hermon within a map of Syria and included footage connected with Israeli strikes on Damascus. Then came the August incident. This public display of hate has moved beyond support for Gaza. Soldiers were chanting direct threats against Jews.



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The Damascus Prophecy

The prophet Isaiah wrote Scripture's most famous statements concerning Syria's capital: "The burden of Damascus. Behold, Damascus is taken away from being a city, and it shall be a ruinous heap" (Isaiah 17:1). Damascus is among the world's oldest continuously inhabited cities. It has endured invasion, conquest, regime change, civil war, terrorism, and bombardment. Yet the city remains.

Isaiah 17 ultimately points toward the destruction of Damascus. Some believe Isaiah's prophecy was fulfilled in the eighth century B.C. through the Assyrian conquest of Israel's ten northern tribes. Bible prophecy should never require us to force today's headlines into Scripture. However, we know Damascus is specifically identified, as is its future destruction.

Isaiah 17 Is About More Than Syria

There is another important element often overlooked when Isaiah 17 is discussed.

The chapter does not speak exclusively about Damascus. It also speaks about Israel. The prophet writes: "The fortress also shall cease from Ephraim, and the kingdom from Damascus." (Isaiah 17:3) The prophecy places Syria and Israel within the same geopolitical judgment. That makes Isaiah 17 particularly interesting in our generation. Modern Israel was reborn in 1948. Syria and Israel have technically remained enemies ever since. They fought major wars in 1948, 1967, and 1973. Israel captured the Golan Heights from Syria during the Six-Day War, and the territory remains one of the central strategic disputes between the two nations.



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The Golan Heights: Israel's Northern Shield

To understand why Syria matters so much to Israel, one just needs to look at a map.

The Golan Heights overlooks northern Israel. Damascus lies just forty miles north. Whoever controls those elevations possesses an enormous strategic advantage. Before Israel captured the territory in 1967, Syrian forces regularly used the heights to threaten Israeli communities below. Today the Golan remains one of Israel's most strategically defensive regions.

The fall of Assad dramatically changed the security environment along Israel's northeastern frontier. Israel became deeply concerned that weapons, territory, and military infrastructure could fall under the control of hostile Islamic forces.

Those concerns did not disappear simply because Assad disappeared.

The question became: Who will replace him? The chants coming from Syrian military personnel provide at least one troubling piece of evidence. They do not prove that Syria has decided to launch a war against Israel. This does not mean Isaiah 17 is being fulfilled tomorrow. But this does reveal something about

the ideological currents that remain alive inside the country.

When Anti-Israel Becomes Anti-Jewish

There is another aspect Christians should recognize. There is a difference between criticizing the policies of the Israeli government and threatening Jews because they are Jews. Governments may legitimately be criticized. Israeli policies, like the policies of every government, can be debated. But when political opposition becomes ethnic or religious hatred, something fundamentally different has occurred.

The reported Syrian chant did not merely address an Israeli administration. It addressed "the Jew." That should trouble every Christian.

Scripture teaches that the Jewish people occupy a unique place in God's redemptive history. The Apostle Paul wrote: "As concerning the gospel, they are enemies for your sakes: but as touching the election, they are beloved for the fathers' sakes. For the gifts and calling of God are without repentance" (Romans 11:28-29).

God has not forgotten Israel. And neither has Satan. Throughout history, a pattern of hatred has followed the Jewish people from nation to nation. Egypt tried to destroy them. Haman plotted their annihilation in Persia. Rome scattered them.

European pogroms persecuted them. Nazi Germany attempted to exterminate them. Yet Israel exists. The Jewish people survived. And nearly two thousand years after Rome scattered them, a Jewish state exists once again in the land of their ancestors. For the Bible prophecy student, that fact is monumental.

The Nations Are Watching Israel

Zechariah describes a future period when Jerusalem will become the center of international conflict: "And in that day will I make Jerusalem a burdensome stone for all people" (Zechariah 12:3). Notice the progression. The prophecy becomes international. Jerusalem has become a global problem. That may have sounded impossible when Zechariah wrote it, but today it sounds familiar.

Israel is one of the smallest nations on earth, yet decisions concerning Jerusalem, Gaza, the West Bank, Iran, Syria, Lebanon, and the Golan Heights repeatedly dominate international news.

The United Nations debates Israel.
European governments debate Israel.
Arab governments debate Israel.
Washington debates Israel.
Universities protest Israel.
Crowds march over Israel.

And now Syrian soldiers are once again directing violent threats toward Jews. Jerusalem's importance cannot be measured merely in square miles. Jerusalem sits at the center of the Biblical story.

Syria and the Coming Middle Eastern Alignment

Syria sits between several major prophetic and geopolitical actors. Turkey to the north. Israel to the southwest. Iraq to the east. Lebanon and the Mediterranean to the west. Iran has spent decades using Syria and Lebanon to aid in their attacks against Israel.

Russia established a major military presence in Syria during the Assad era. Turkey has enormous strategic interests in northern Syria. Israel considers developments inside Syria a direct national-security concern. In other words, Syria sits at a key geopolitical intersection.

Do Not Set Dates--Watch Direction

Whenever dramatic events occur in the Middle East, believers face two opposite dangers. The first is sensationalism. Every missile is not Armageddon. Every Middle Eastern war is not automatically Ezekiel 38. Every crisis involving Damascus does not prove Isaiah 17 is being fulfilled that afternoon. Jesus specifically warned against deception. Prophecy requires discernment.

The second danger is equally serious: indifference. Jesus repeatedly commanded His followers to watch. Biblical watchfulness does not mean predicting dates. It means recognizing direction or seasons. And several directions are becoming difficult to miss. Israel is increasingly isolated internationally. Antisemitism has resurfaced openly around the world. Iran remains confronting Israel. Turkey's regional influence continues to grow. Syria's

future remains uncertain.

Adding that all up and one sees a season of the Middle East undergoing enormous political realignment. Jerusalem remains at the center of international controversy.

None of those developments individually proves that a particular prophecy is being fulfilled. Together, however, they should remind Christians that the geopolitical world described by the prophets no longer seems impossible.

Imagine Reading the Prophets 100 Years Ago. Consider what a Christian reading Bible prophecy in 1926 would have encountered.

Israel was not a sovereign nation.

Jerusalem was not Israel's capital.

The Jewish people were scattered throughout the world.

There was no Israeli military.

There was no modern Israeli-Syrian border.

There was no modern Iran-Israel conflict.

Many prophetic passages seemed geopolitically impossible. Then history began moving. Israel became a nation in 1948. Jerusalem returned to Jewish control in 1967. The Jewish population of Israel grew into the millions. Ancient regional enemies reemerged in modern political forms. Jerusalem became an international controversy. Suddenly passages written thousands of years ago could be read against an astonishingly recognizable geographic landscape. That gives us reason to take prophecy seriously.

Damascus Is Worth Watching

So, what should we make of Syrian soldiers chanting threats against Jews? True, normally a military chant is not a declaration of war. Soldiers participating in a demonstration do not necessarily speak for every Syrian citizen or every policy of the Syrian government. However, this does not eliminate legitimate concern over Islamic extremism and antisemitism hostility.

The Gospel calls us to love people while recognizing dangerous ideologies.

But when armed soldiers in Damascus chant openly about Jewish blood, the world should pay attention. And Bible students should remember where they are standing. Damascus. A city specifically named by the prophet Isaiah. Forty miles from Israel's border. This in a country whose political future remains unsettled.

In a region undergoing historic transformation and in a world where hostility toward Israel is becoming increasingly visible.

The Bigger Prophetic Picture

Perhaps the greatest prophetic significance of this story is not the chant itself.

It is the environment in which the chant occurred. Israel is fighting threats on multiple fronts. Antisemitism is becoming increasingly public. And nations are being forced to decide where they stand concerning Israel and Jerusalem.

Scripture tells us that a day is coming when that question will engulf the nations.

Zechariah declares: "Behold, I will make Jerusalem a cup of trembling unto all the people round about." (Zechariah 12:2) The church cannot afford to sleep through the transformation occurring before us.

Watch Damascus. Watch Jerusalem.

The Syrian soldiers' chants will eventually disappear from the news cycle. Another crisis will replace them. Another election. Another diplomatic summit. Another technological breakthrough. That is how the modern news cycle works. But Scripture gives believers a longer perspective. Nations rise and nations fall. Leaders come and leaders go. Military alliances change. Borders move.

Yet God's prophetic Word continues moving toward its appointed conclusion.

So when threatening voices rise from Damascus, perhaps Christians should do more than watch a video and scroll to the next story. We should open Isaiah. We should read Ezekiel. We should study Zechariah. We should pray for Israel. We should pray for the people of Syria. We should reject antisemitism wherever it appears. We should proclaim the Gospel while the opportunity remains. And above all, we should remember the words of Jesus: "And when these things begin to come to pass, then look up, and lift up your heads; for your redemption draweth nigh." (Luke 21:28)



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